



Sphalerite

△ **Ruby blende**, a red variety of sphalerite

Sphalerite gemstones are rare. This is not because the stone itself is rare, but because it is possibly the most difficult of all gems to cut. The stone can easily shatter into small pieces during cutting: the ability to facet sphalerite is the mark of a master cutter. For this reason, stones are faceted only for collectors. Sphalerite takes its name from the Greek *sphaleros*, meaning “treacherous”, referring to the fact that it occurs in a number of forms that can be mistaken for other minerals. Its usual colour is greenish yellow, but it can also be ruby red.

Specification

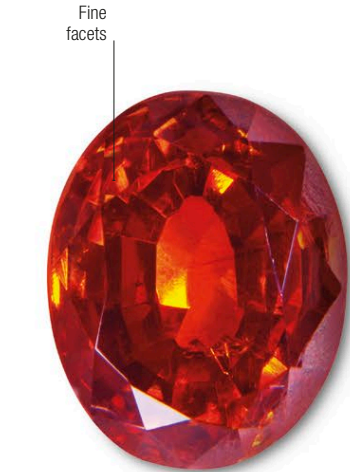
Chemical name Zinc sulphide | **Formula** ZnS
Colours Yellow-green, red, brown, black | **Structure** Cubic
Hardness 3.5–4 | **SG** 3.9–4.1 | **RI** 2.36–2.37 | **Lustre** Resinous to adamantine | **Streak** Brownish to light yellow
Locations Russia, Spain, Mexico, Canada, USA



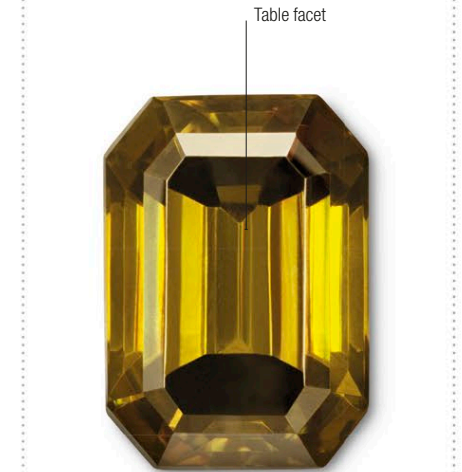
Baryte on sphalerite | Rough | This specimen consists of a mass of elongated, platy baryte crystals resting on a bed of sphalerite crystals.



Gem sphalerite | Rough | Here, a large, gem-quality sphalerite crystal can be seen embedded in smaller crystals of sphalerite and quartz.



Faceted oval | Cut | The superb cut of this oval sphalerite gemstone brings out one of the mineral’s more unusual colours, a deep red hue.



Emerald cut | Cut | Because of sphalerite’s extreme brittleness, stones with corners of any kind are difficult to cut, so this emerald-cut gem displays exceptional craftsmanship.



Scissors cut | Cut | The cutter of this sphalerite gem has used the complexity of a modified scissors cut to help disguise the stone’s internal colour variations.